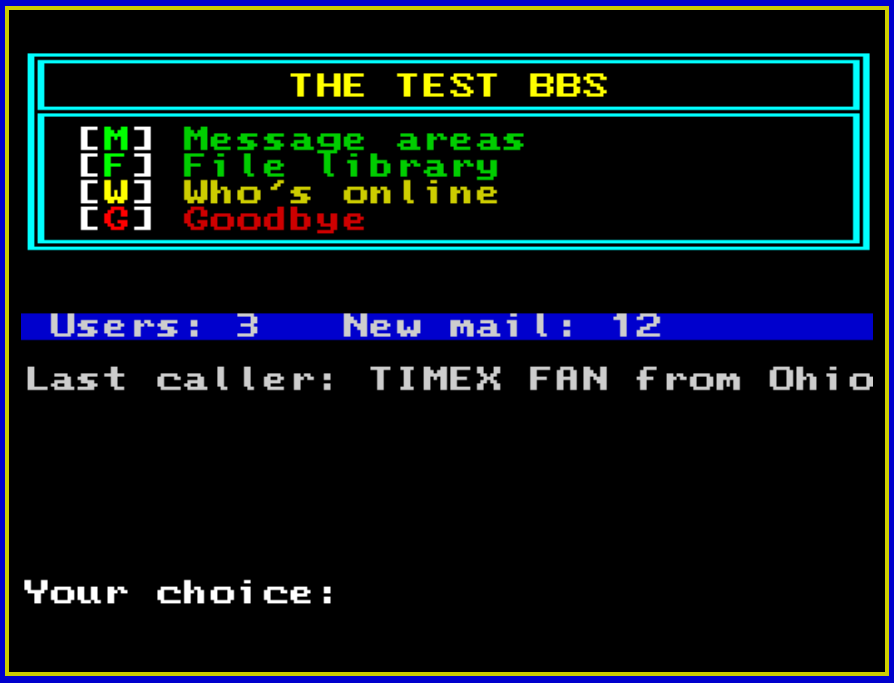
TIMEX/SINCLAIR 2068 · TS-PICO V3 · 2026

PICOTERM

USER MANUAL

A terminal program for the TS-2068 and the TS-Pico v3 card. The card's WiFi modem runs Zimodem, and PicoTerm uses it to reach telnet BBSes: ANSI color and box drawing, 32 or 64 columns (80 with PicoVideo), a phonebook, and XMODEM downloads to the SD card.



TS-2068 + TS-Pico v3 · WiFi

Version 0.6, 2026

timexsinclair.com



PicoTerm 0.6 © 2026. Written in Z80 assembly for the TS-Pico v3 card.

Built on Bo Zimmerman's Zimodem, the TS-Pico firmware and ROM, and the TS 2068 Technical Manual's Video Mode Change Service (as Zebra's OS-64 uses it). The CP437 font is PicoVideo's: Bm437_ACM_VGA_8x8 from VileR's Ultimate Oldschool PC Font Pack (int10h.org), CC BY-SA 4.0.

This manual was written from the program itself. Its screenshots come from PicoTerm's own code run on a model of the 2068 with a simulated modem and BBS, so the BBS screens are examples.

`picoterm.tap: loader CLEAR 34815: LOAD "" CODE: RANDOMIZE USR 34816 · code at 8800h · 8251 $73/$77 · TS-Pico 14/15 · AY F5h/F6h`

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KEYS IN THIS MANUAL

CAPS is CAPS SHIFT and SYM is SYMBOL SHIFT. BREAK is CAPS+SPACE; it opens PicoTerm's menu, and in any PicoTerm screen it goes back one step.

01 WHAT YOU NEED

- **A TS-2068** with the TS-Pico ROM 2.3 or later.
- **The TS-Pico v3 card**, with firmware that has the TS2050 modem emulation (the 8251 at ports `$73` and `$77`), and Zimodem on the card's ESP32. The card's modem has to be in *Hayes mode*. PicoTerm switches it there itself where the firmware allows.
- **A WiFi network** the card can join. PicoTerm can scan for one and join it (section 9).
- **An SD card in the TS-Pico**, for `picoterm.cfg` (your settings and phonebook) and for downloads.
- *Optional:* **PicoVideo**, for 80 columns and for color in 64 columns, on its VGA output.

A REAL TS2050?

PicoTerm is written for the TS-Pico's modem. It doesn't pulse-dial, and it doesn't watch the TS2050's carrier line, so it won't drive an original 300-baud TS2050. Use MTERM for that.

02 LOADING PICOTERM

`picoterm.tap` holds a one-line BASIC loader and about 15 KB of machine code, which loads at 34816 (8800h).

1. Copy `picoterm.tap` to the SD card's `/TAP` folder.
2. Type `LOAD "tpi:picoterm.tap"` `ENTER` to mount it.
3. Type `LOAD ""` `ENTER`. The loader runs by itself.

WHAT HAPPENS AT START-UP

1. PicoTerm reads `picoterm.cfg` from the card's current folder, if there is one, and sets up the screen in its column mode.
2. It puts the card's modem in Hayes mode (`tpi:modem hayes`).
3. It resets the 8251, which starts the card's ESP32.
4. It sends `AT` once a second until Zimodem answers `OK` (up to about 12 s; Zimodem's banner may show first), then your init string (`ATE1V1X1Q0`) and the telnet terminal type (`AT&S"41=ANSI"`).
5. It turns on flow control: `ATF1`, then `tpi:modem flow on`. Older firmware refuses, and PicoTerm carries on without.
6. It shows `Modem ready.` You see everything the modem says. If something is missing, a message says so and PicoTerm carries on (section 12).

HAYES MODE STAYS

The TS-Pico saves the modem's mode in `config.ini`, so the card stays in Hayes mode after you quit. Before loading MTERM or another TS2050 program, type `SAVE "tpi:modem 2050"`.

MEMORY

The loader does `CLEAR 34815`. PicoTerm also opens the second display file with the ROM's Video Mode Change Service, as OS-64 does, which moves BASIC up to 7B00h. It stays open after you quit, so BASIC has about 7 KB less room until you reset.

03 YOUR FIRST CALL

Once the modem is ready, everything you type goes to it. Zimodem echoes your typing and answers in words (`OK`, `CONNECT`, `NO CARRIER`), like a Hayes modem.

1. **Join your WiFi**, once: `BREAK`, then `W` (section 9).
2. **Dial a host** by typing its address in quotes: `ATDTX"bbs.example.com:23"` `ENTER`. The `T` asks for telnet, which most BBSes want, and the `X` turns on flow control. `ATDX"…"` is a raw TCP port.
3. Zimodem answers `CONNECT`. From now on everything you type goes to the BBS.
4. **To hang up:** `BREAK`, then `H`. If the BBS hangs up first, you see `NO CARRIER`.

Put the hosts you use in the phonebook (section 8) and dial them with one key; it adds the `X` itself.

WHY THE X

When the BBS sends faster than the 2068 draws, the card tells Zimodem to pause and go on (XOFF, XON). Zimodem obeys only on a call dialed with `X`; without it a fast host can overrun the card. It needs firmware with `tpi:modem flow`.



Dialing by hand: ATDTX, CONNECT, the BBS's greeting.

04 THE KEYBOARD

Letters, digits and SPACE type as you'd expect; CAPS gives capitals. Every other ASCII character and control key is on a shifted key. A held key repeats after about half a second.

KEYS	LEGEND	SENDS OR DOES
CAPS+1	EDIT	**Esc** (1Bh)
CAPS+2	CAPS LOCK	Caps lock, for letters
CAPS+3	TRUE VID	**Tab** (09h)
CAPS+5–8	← ↓ ↑ →	**Arrows:** `ESC [ D B A C` (ANSI, TTY), `ESC D B A C` (VT52). In PicoTerm's screens they move the selection.
CAPS+9	GRAPHICS	**Next column mode:** 32, 64, 80
CAPS+0	DELETE	**Backspace:** BS (08h) or DEL (7Fh), as set
BREAK	BREAK	**The PicoTerm menu**; in a menu, back
ENTER		CR, or CR LF as set

CONTROL KEYS

Press CAPS and SYM together, let go, then press a letter: PicoTerm sends it as a control key. CAPS+SYM, C sends **Ctrl-C**. Pressing CAPS+SYM twice cancels it. It works for the letters and [\ ] ^ _. With flow control, Zimodem keeps Ctrl-S and Ctrl-Q for itself.

SYMBOL SHIFT

The red symbols work as in BASIC. The keys that type keywords give the ASCII characters the 2068 can't otherwise type:

KEY	SENDS	KEY	SENDS	KEY	SENDS
SYM+A	~	SYM+S	|	SYM+D	\
SYM+F	{	SYM+G	}	SYM+H	^
SYM+Y	[	SYM+U	]	SYM+X	` (not £)

KEY	SENDS	KEY	SENDS	KEY	SENDS
SYM+Z	:	SYM+C	?	SYM+V	/
SYM+R	<	SYM+T	>	SYM+O	;
SYM+P	"	SYM+J	-	SYM+K	+
SYM+L	=	SYM+B	*	SYM+N	,
SYM+M	.	SYM+1...0:	! @ # $ % & ' ( ) _		

SYM with Q, W, E or I (≤ ≠ ≥ AT) sends nothing.

05 THE TERMINAL

PicoTerm has three emulations. It uses ANSI unless you choose otherwise in Settings or in a phonebook entry, and it tells Zimodem which one to report to telnet hosts.

EMULATION	WHAT IT UNDERSTANDS
ANSI	For BBSes: a VT100 subset with color, as BBS software expects of "ANSI-BBS". • Cursor moves, positioning, save and restore. • Erasing; inserting and deleting lines and characters. • A scrolling region. • Colors with bold, blink and reverse. • It answers the cursor-position question, which BBSes use to find the screen size, and identifies itself as a VT100.
VT52	The standard set: cursor moves, home, `ESC Y` addressing, erasing, reverse line feed, identify.
TTY	Text and control codes only; escape sequences show as text.

In every emulation PicoTerm handles **BEL**, a short tone on the AY; **BS**; **Tab**, every 8 columns; **LF**; **CR**; and **FF**, which clears the screen. Text wraps as on a VT100: a character in the last column leaves the cursor there, and the next starts a new line.

COLOR AND CHARACTERS

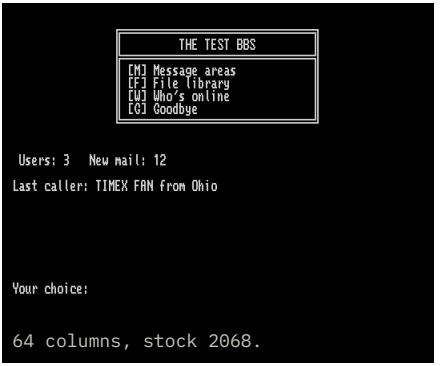
ANSI's eight colors become the 2068's. **Bold** is BRIGHT, **blink** is FLASH (or not, in Settings), and **reverse** swaps ink and paper. BRIGHT lights the whole cell, so bold text on a colored background brightens the background too.

PicoTerm uses the PC's CP437 characters, as PicoVideo does for 80 columns, so box lines, shading and accented letters look as BBS authors meant.

06 32, 64 AND 80 COLUMNS

CAPS+9 changes mode, keeping what's on screen. Settings C picks the mode PicoTerm starts in.

MODE	NEEDS	COLOR
32	any 2068	Per character. Readable on any TV.
64	any 2068	One ink and paper (Settings I); per character with PicoVideo.
80	PicoVideo	Per character, on VGA. The 2068's own video shows nothing useful. Turn on **PicoVideo** in Settings.







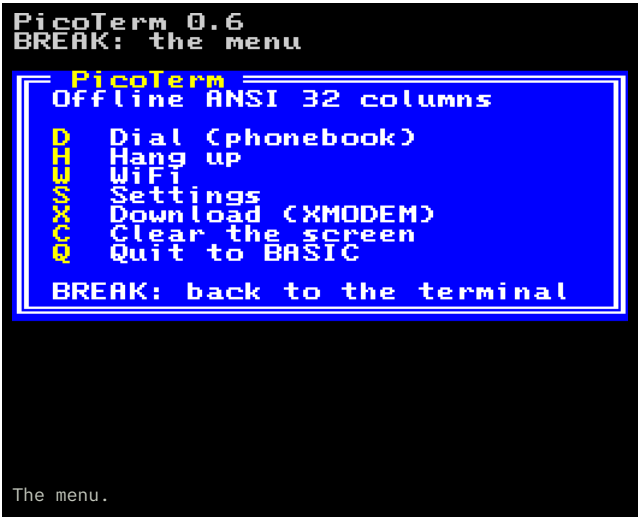
The screen is 24 rows. A line scrolls in about 40 ms in 32 and 80 columns and 100 ms in 64: fast enough for 2400 baud.

07 THE MENU

Press BREAK at any time. The menu's top line says whether you're online, and the emulation and columns in use.

KEY	DOES
D	The phonebook: dial, add, edit, delete
H	Hang up
W	WiFi: scan, join, save
S	Settings
X	Download a file (XMODEM)
C	Clear the screen
Q	Quit to BASIC; hangs up first if online
BREAK	Back to the terminal

Text from the BBS waits while a menu is open, and appears when you return.



08 THE PHONEBOOK

20 hosts. Move with CAPS+6 and CAPS+7.

KEY	DOES
ENTER	**Dial**: applies the entry's settings, goes back to the terminal, sends `ATDTX"host:port"` (`ATDX` with telnet off).
N	**New**: the name, ENTER, the host, ENTER, then ENTER to save. It starts with your current settings.
E / X	**Edit / delete** (Y confirms).



The phonebook.

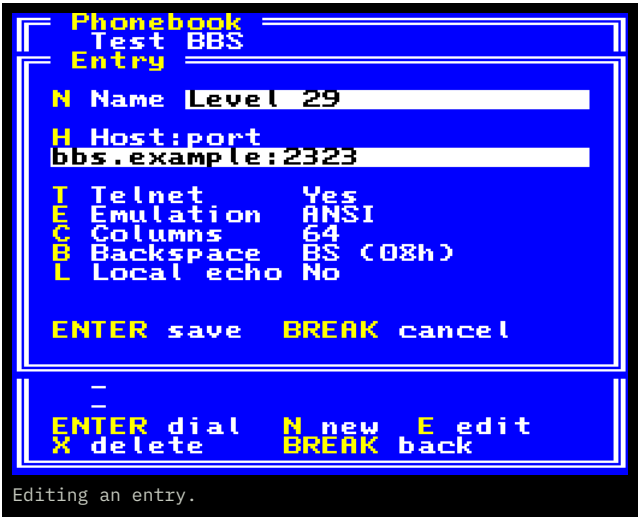
REMEMBER TO SAVE

Entries live in memory until you save your settings (Settings S). Dialing while online is refused: “Hang up first.”

AN ENTRY

KEY	FIELD	NOTES
N	Name	Up to 16 characters
H	Host:port	Up to 40, e.g. `bbs.example.com:23`
T	Telnet	Yes: `ATDT`. No: `ATD`, raw TCP
E	Emulation	ANSI, VT52, TTY
C	Columns	32, 64, 80 (64 without PicoVideo)
B	Backspace	BS or DEL, as the host wants
L	Local echo	For hosts that don't echo

ENTER saves the entry; BREAK drops the changes. In a text field DELETE rubs out and ENTER accepts.



09 WIFI

`BREAK`, then `W`, while offline. Zimodem scans (`ATW`) and PicoTerm lists up to 16 networks.

1. Choose one with the arrows and press `ENTER`, or `M` to type a name that isn't listed. `R` scans again.
2. Type the password (it shows as stars) and press `ENTER`. PicoTerm sends `ATW"name,password"` and waits up to 20 s.
3. If it worked, `Y` makes it the default (`AT&W`): Zimodem joins it by itself from then on.



COMMAS AND QUOTES

Zimodem's `ATW"name,password"` can't carry a comma or a `"` in either part.

10 SETTINGS

BREAK, then S. Each key changes one setting at once.

KEY	SETTING	DEFAULT
E	Emulation	ANSI
C	Columns at start-up	32
P	PicoVideo fitted	No
I	64-column ink	White
B	Backspace: BS or DEL	BS
L	Local echo	No
N	ENTER sends CR or CR LF	CR
F	Blink shows as FLASH	Yes
G	Bell	Yes
M	Modem init string	`ATE1V1X1Q0`
S	**Save** settings and phonebook	

PICOTERM.CFG

S writes `picoterm.cfg` in the SD card's current folder; PicoTerm reads it at start-up. It's plain text: `emul=2` (0 TTY, 1 VT52, 2 ANSI), `cols=1` (0 is 32, 1 is 64, 2 is 80), `picovideo`, `ink64`, `bs` (8 or 127), `echo`, `enter`, `blink`, `bell`, `init`, and a line per phonebook entry:

```
phone=Test BBS|bbs.example.com:23|1|2|0|8|0
```

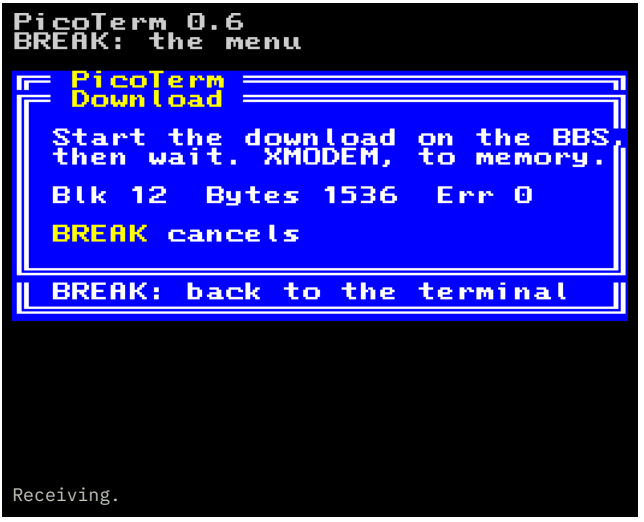
That's the name, host, telnet, emulation, columns, backspace and echo. Lines PicoTerm doesn't understand are skipped.

11 DOWNLOADING FILES

PicoTerm receives with **XMODEM**, CRC or 1K, with checksums for older senders. The file goes to the TS-Pico's SD card.

1. On the BBS, choose the file and XMODEM.
2. BREAK, X, and a name for the file (`download.bin`). PicoTerm asks before replacing a file.
3. The window counts blocks, bytes and errors. Damaged blocks are asked for again.
4. **Strip ^Z padding?** XMODEM pads the last block with 1Ah. Y for text; N for programs and binaries.
5. PicoTerm saves the file and shows its size.

BREAK cancels and tells the BBS. In stock 64-column mode, PicoTerm uses 32 columns during the transfer: the file is held in the 64-column screen's memory.



IN THIS VERSION

Downloads are received into memory first: at most **6,912 bytes**. The file is saved as `SAVE "f:name" CODE` saves it, so it starts with a 128-byte +3DOS header. `LOAD "f:name" CODE` loads it back; on a PC, cut the first 128 bytes. A planned TS-Pico firmware addition should lift both limits.

12 MESSAGES AND PROBLEMS

YOU SEE	IT MEANS, AND WHAT TO DO
`Modem ready.`	Zimodem answered. Type or dial.
`This TS-Pico has no tpi:modem.`	Older card firmware. Set the card's modem to Hayes mode yourself (see the TS-Pico manual), or update.
`No modem: the 8251 isn't ready.`	Nothing at `$73` / `$77` within 5 s: no v3 card, the modem off, or no modem firmware. PicoTerm runs; modem keys are dropped.
`No answer from the modem.`	No `OK` in about 12 s. Check the modem is in **Hayes** mode (TS2050 mode hides Zimodem's replies), then type `AT` `ENTER`.
`NO ANSWER`, `ERROR`	Zimodem couldn't connect, or didn't understand: check the host, port, quotes and WiFi (`ATI` shows Zimodem's state).
`NO CARRIER`	The host hung up.
`Hang up first.`	Dialing or WiFi while online: `BREAK`, `H`.
`Couldn't save the settings.`	No TS-Pico or SD card, or the card refused.
`Too big for memory (6912).`	The download was too long for this version.
`The sender didn't start.`	Nothing from the BBS for about 30 s. Start the download on the BBS first.
`Too many errors. Canceled.`	Ten bad blocks in a row. Try again.

SLOW TEXT

The card passes text to the 2068 no faster than its `MODEM_BAUD` setting: 300 baud unless changed, 30 characters a second. Raise it in the TS-Pico's `config.ini`: `0` (no limit) is safe with flow control. Without it, keep to about 2400, or a fast host can overrun the card.

TEXT MISSING IN A FAST STREAM

Dial with the `X` (`ATDTX`, or the phonebook), and check the card's firmware has `tpi:modem flow`.

13 LIMITS

- **Downloads only, and at most 6,912 bytes**: no upload, YMODEM or ZMODEM, and no capture to a file.
- **No scrollback.** Text that scrolls off the top is gone.
- **24 rows.** BBSes that assume 25 lose the bottom line.
- **Color:** no bright background on its own; 64 columns on a stock 2068 has one color pair.
- **Keyboard:** the symbol keys follow the Spectrum's legends, which the 2068 mostly shares; the tables in section 4 are what PicoTerm does.
- **Screen width:** PicoTerm can't tell a telnet host your width itself. Most BBSes ask, or measure it with the cursor-position question, which PicoTerm answers.
- **The modem:** the TS-Pico's, in Hayes mode, with its 8251 emulation. Not a stock TS2050.
- **Ctrl-S and Ctrl-Q** don't reach the host on a call with flow control.

14 ABOUT THIS EDITION

PicoTerm 0.6, 2026, for the TS-Pico v3 card, in Z80 assembly (sjasmplus). This manual was written from the program itself; the BBS screens are examples from a simulated BBS, not real systems. Credits are inside the front cover.

YOUR BBS LIST

NAME	HOST:PORT	TELNET	COLS	NOTES

QUICK REFERENCE

KEY	IN THE TERMINAL
BREAK	Menu
CAPS + 1	Esc
CAPS + 2	Caps lock
CAPS + 3	Tab
CAPS + 5–8	Arrows
CAPS + 9	32 / 64 / 80
CAPS + 0	Backspace
CAPS + SYM, key	Ctrl-key
SYM + A S D	~ | \
SYM + F G H	{ } ^
SYM + Y U X	[ ] `

KEY	IN THE MENU
D	Phonebook
H	Hang up
W	WiFi
S	Settings (S saves)
X	XMODEM download
C	Clear the screen
Q	Quit to BASIC
BREAK	Back

DIALING BY HAND

`ATDTX"host:port"` telnet · `ATDX"host:port"` raw · `ATI` status · `ATW` scan WiFi

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